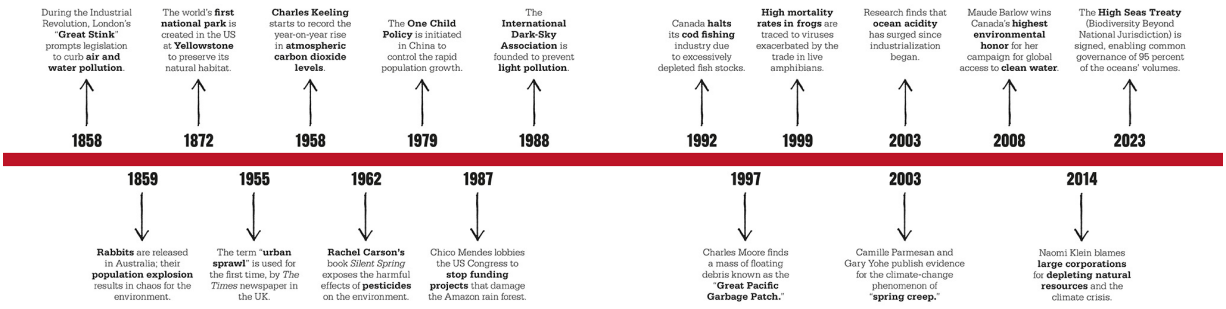
INTRODUCTION

Raw sewage produced by millions of Londoners once poured into the Thames River for decades, until the stench of the effluent became so bad that in 1858 action was demanded. When a new system of sewers, pumping stations, and treatment works revolutionized the city's sanitation, deaths and illness from cholera and other bacterial infections fell dramatically, and the river became much cleaner.

Human activity has always altered the environment, but its impact increased dramatically in the mid-18th century with the Industrial Revolution that began in Britain, and spread to Europe, North America, and beyond. The negative effects can be broadly divided into pollution, and destruction of resources and habitats.

Scottish-American environmentalist John Muir was one of the first to identify habitat degradation and destruction as problems, and in 1890 he won protection for the Yosemite Valley in California. However, despite a steady increase in protected natural environments, with a call now for 30 percent of Earth's land and sea to be protected, the destructive pressures of human development have grown ever more powerful.



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